Essay Outline: Contract of McMillan & Vasseur and Smith & Sobel

Introduction:

Hook: Environmental education can be very different depending on if it's done through the lens of academic research or practical and engaging classroom stories.

Context: While both articles promote ecological awareness, they differ significantly in conventions, purposes, and perspectives: McMillan & Vasseur use an academic style to argue for interdisciplinarity in policy and curriculum reform, whereas Smith & Sobel opt for an engaging story-driven approach to highlight how place-based education can benefit students and local communities.

Body Paragraph 1: Conventions

Topic Sentence: McMillan & Vasseur's article uses academic conventions and technical register, while Smith & Sobel opts for a magazine style with accessible storytelling.

- **McMillan & Vasseur**:
  - Journal format (*International Journal of Interdisciplinary Social Sciences*).
  - Formal, dense language: "interdisciplinary education," "critical self-reflection" (p. 438).
  - Frequent citations (Orr, 1992; Jickling, 1994; Hart, 2008).
  - Structure includes abstract, literature review, methodology, conclusion.

- **Smith & Sobel**:
  - Published in *Educational Leadership* (magazine).
  - Accessible, conversational tone. Example: "The abstract and faraway don't always sustain the interest of the young" (p. 38).
  - Narrative examples: Idaho trout restoration project, school cafeteria solar audits.
  - Uses anecdotes and student voices, minimal citations.

Contrast Point: One appeals to scholars and policymakers through rigorous academic style, while the other reaches teachers and the public through stories and plain language.

Body Paragraph 2: Purpose

Topic Sentence: McMillan & Vasseur aim to advance interdisciplinary theory and systemic reform, while Smith & Sobel seek to inspire educators with concrete local examples.

- **McMillan & Vasseur**:
  - Purpose: advocate for interdisciplinarity as essential to environmental education.
  - Device: reliance on authority, legitimate studies (Millennium Ecosystem Assessment, 2005).
  - Device: abstract argumentation, linking sustainability to ethics, politics, and social values (p. 437–439).

- **Smith & Sobel**:
    - Purpose: motivate educators to adopt place and community-based learning.
    - Device: anecdotal evidence: solar panel projects, hatchery goats, Haiti reconstruction.

Device: emotional appeal, students "gain a sense of leadership and meaning" (p. 42).

Body Paragraph 3: Perspective

Topic Sentence: McMillan & Vasseur take a broad, global policy and ethics perspective, while Smith & Sobel stress local engagement and immediate community action.

- **McMillan & Vasseur**:
    - Perspective: education must prepare students as environmentally responsible citizens by linking multiple disciplines.
    - Emphasis on global crisis: "the ability of the planet's ecosystems to sustain future generations can no longer be taken for granted" (p. 436).
    - Views education as systemic, requiring national and institutional reform.

- **Smith & Sobel**:
    - Perspective: students learn best through personal relevance and local action.
    - Focus on small-scale wins (Idaho students saving trout, solar audits).
    - Emphasis on connection between classroom and community life.

- **Contrast Point**: McMillan & Vasseur address structural and theoretical transformation, while Smith & Sobel highlight pragmatic, grassroots change.

Conclusion

Restate Thesis: Both texts advocate for environmental education but diverge in how they communicate it. One through academic interdisciplinarity, the other through accessible, place-based storytelling.

Closing Thought: Together, the two perspectives show that effective environmental education requires both systemic, theoretical frameworks and local, practical applications to inspire change.

Works Cited

McMillan, E., & Vasseur, L. (2010). *Environmental education: Interdisciplinarity in action*. *International Journal of Interdisciplinary Social Sciences, 5*(3), 435–445.

Smith, G., & Sobel, D. (2010). Bring it on home. *Educational Leadership, 68*(1), 38–43.